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Jason Palmer

Trumpeter, composer, and educator Jason Palmer has appeared on over a hundred recordings as a sideman and has produced numerous critically-acclaimed solo releases. He shares his passion for improvised music with students at Berklee College of Music, and frequently presents master classes both here and abroad.

Jason was interviewed via Zoom on May 2, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Jason Palmer with me this morning, 9:30 AM. Used to be that jazz musicians didn't know about 9:30 AM.

JP: Right? Yeah. Either coming home from a gig or, you know, if you look at those like really consequential Blue Note records, a lot of those were started, you know, they started recording at that time. And you know I met Fred — well I'll just start off with a story. I met Freddie Hubbard back in the late '90s and he told me a lot of those records that they made, you know, were recorded in the morning and so there were times when they would play a gig and they'd play several sets and it'd end at 3, 4, 5 in the morning. They'd go have breakfast and then go to Rudy VanGelder's place. So yeah.

MR: I wonder if that's, you know, adrenaline kicks in. Coffee and whatever else sometimes resulted in terrific records. I remember Joe Williams had the same story about when he did the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis recording and no one had gone to bed yet.

JP: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: Well it's early May and you have Berklee and the New England Conservatory. I wonder if it's sort of crunch time for you and your students?

JP: Yeah. Well I had my last teaching day on Wednesday, so I'm all set with the classroom stuff, I just have to turn my grades in and I have promotionals at New England Conservatory on Monday so I'll be truly finished at the end of the day on Monday. So but yeah it was a race to the finish line with all the recitals and finals and all that stuff, so, but yeah, it was a joy to work with the young artists.

MR: I watched a video of you talking about jazz education. And you felt it was necessary to instill (this is my interpretation) some history and the role of jazz in America. Is that a fair statement?

JP: Yeah. It's one of the — I think it's one of the most valuable contributions this country has made to the world you know, it really — it exhibits the potential that we have to all come together. You know this music you know integrated before baseball. There has

been significant contributions by every part of the society to the music. So I think those little historical things need to be also taught besides the playing part. You know? I think it's important for us to have a perspective on, you know, the history of the music and why people play it, how people play, how people got together, you know the stories behind the songs, you know, just all the important things that you usually would find in liner notes.

MR: Liner notes. That's where my education came from. And I had made a note, you had a — sorry about that fan — you had a recording called "Places" I believe. And you had extensive liner notes and I said, yeah, I gave that a thumbs up.

JP: Um hum. Yeah I write all the liner notes to all of my records. I've gotten about 20 of them out commercially and yeah, I've written to all of them I believe.

MR: Yeah — I'm debating — do you hear that noise as much as I do?

JP: It doesn't bother me.

MR: Okay, we'll proceed and it will go off in a while. You know who agrees with you about what you just said is Lionel Hampton. I had the pleasure of talking to him, God, like 25 years ago, and he said, Teddy Wilson used to play when Benny Goodman took an intermission and no white musician was on stage, then Teddy would play by himself. So I was the first one to break that tradition down. But the think about it, there was no black and white playing together no place. Not in moving pictures, not in baseball, football, no kind of sports."

JP: Yeah. Un hum. Yup. There you go.

MR: How do you find time to work that into your lessons?

JP: You know it depends on the student. You know at Berklee I teach in the ensemble department so a lot of times I'm coaching ensembles and so what I do is when I bring in repertoire, I try to bring in songs that have stories behind them or some kind of historical reference or whatnot. And I try to take at least a week where we'll go maybe have pizza or I'll host a recording session — not recording — a listening session where I'll play recordings, historical recordings, and we'll just talk outside of class time. And I usually do that towards the end of the semester, especially for the students who — my role at Berklee is I work in the Ensemble Department and there they have certain levels for all the ensembles in order for all the students to be hopefully placed in groups where they all have the same or similar level of playing and experience. And so I'm dealing with levels 3s, 4s, and 5s, which is the mid-level. 6, 7, 8 are the upper levels. So I'm dealing with a lot of students who are pretty new to the music. They may not know who all the great players are. So I tend to spend a little more time, you know, bringing in historical recordings and even some recordings and charts of our contemporaries that are really writing music that has a really strong steep in the tradition but also, you know, trying to find new things within compositional practices and everything. So I try to do a mix, and

you know it all varies from ensemble to ensemble. You know some ensembles I'll get where a lot of the students want to play straight ahead and then I have some ensembles where they want to, you know, learn the modern thing and play songs from contemporaries. So what I do in the beginning of the semester is always interview the students in the ensembles. I'll ask okay what have you been listening to, how long have you been playing, you know did you grow up in a musical family. And so what that does is it kind of informs me as to what they like and what I think could help them get to the next level. You know, so based on what they already know and where their skill level is then I'll just bring in things that I think will really augment their time, you know, with me in the semester.

MR: I'm going to guess that you have to be prepared not to react negatively when — like a trumpet student and you say "Roy Eldridge" and they have a blank response.

JP: Of course. Yeah, yeah. I mean I kind of look back to when I was their age. You know? There are a lot of trumpet players I didn't know about, you know, and thank goodness I had teachers that were on the scene that knew who was who and they guided me in the right direction. So yeah I can never really blame the young folk for not really knowing. When they're in front of me I think it's my responsibility to, you know, share what I know and hopefully you know light a spark, give them an AHA! moment. They say okay, yeah, I've never heard of Roy Eldridge, Roy Hargrove, you know I've gotten great trumpet players who never heard of Roy Hargrove you know? And he was on the scene for many decades up until less than ten years ago when he passed away. So yeah, it's like you just accept them where they are, you just kind of build them up. You know that's my m.o.

MR: Do you get a sense of — as an educator — a responsibility to make your students aware of the employment opportunities these days — making a living in music. Do you talk about that? Like here's what you need to know and here's how you need to be?

JP: Yeah. That comes up a lot you know, especially with students who, you know at Berklee they have a lot of different majors. You know you can major in music business, you can major in production, engineering, you know music therapy, whatever. But you know you also have performance majors who want to focus primarily on performance. So you know with those students we talk about what you need to do, how you need to be prepared, and also I try to show them, you know, this is a program that you should be going to in the summer. You know you should think about going to Siena, going to Jazz Ahead or going to Ravinia and meeting people who are serious and you know, forming those bonds. Because you know generationally those are going to be the players that you're going to be playing with for the majority of your career. I mean that was my experience. And so you know I try to relate the experiences I've had, and also understand that you know my

experiences won't necessarily be their experience but I just have to let them know okay this is what I went through and, you know, it's a possibility for you as well. Another thing that I like to talk about a lot is royalties and having your music published and having it registered so you can really recoup the royalties that you're entitled to even outside of just recording your music. Because I think a lot of students, they know that, okay if I put a record out then if it gets radio play or whatever, you know I'm entitled to royalties, but they don't really understand that if you play your tunes at a gig then you're also entitled to royalties because in this country a lot of those performance venues they have to pay a fee in order to have music at the venues. And so there are programs set up through BMI and ASCAP and all those — SECAC — that you know give royalties towards live performance. And so I always try to talk to them about those different kind of avenues of income possibilities. But yeah, it's always a challenge for sure.

MR: Do you have to do something from your end — if you're playing at a club in New York and you have your original music in a set, are you supposed to do something to inform those organizations that you indeed have played your original music in X club on X date.

JP: Yeah absolutely, in the U.S. you do. I'm registered with ASCAP and they have a program called the Performance Plus Awards Program. And so what you do is you fill out, you can do it once a year or twice a year. You fill out a form that says okay on this date I played these tunes at this venue, and you have a whole spreadsheet. And I think it's retroactive about a couple of years now. Maybe it's gotten wider. So if you just joined, if you have a record of where you played, if you've got programs and all that stuff so we can really track what you played and where you played. And once you submit those forms those songs, they all, in the venues, they all have an algorithm, you know based on how much they contribute, how big the venue is, you know, and the publishing deal you have with the compositions that you played, that all generates a fee that you'll get as a royalty payment. And so depending on how much you play in the U.S. you know there's fees that you are entitled to. Because a lot of times you know people don't do it and that money is staying in the account of those professional PROs organizations. And it's just sitting there drawing interest and the musicians, you know, don't have a means to track it down. But you know in Europe it's different. When I play a concert there as a leader the director of the venue they'll come to me and they'll bring the form to me. And I just write down, you know, the songs that I played. I'm sure a lot of musicians that have been to Europe and abroad have experienced that kind of thing. And so then, then you get royalties that way and you only have to fill out a form. In the U.S. it's all done online now, I mean since I've been doing it it's all been online.

MR: I've read your list of albums under your own name, and then I guess about 40 albums as a sideman.

JP: Yeah I'm up to about a hundred now.

MR: Now you're up to a hundred.

JP: Yeah, it's not up to date, yeah.

MR: Well that helps me with my question. Why? Why do so many other jazz musicians want you on their recordings? So set your modesty aside and tell me.

JP: Oh Jeez I wish I knew. Well you know the trumpet is a very — I wouldn't want to say unforgiving but it's an instrument that takes a lot of work to really make it a very malleable instrument. It's an instrument that, it takes a lot, you've got to do a lot of work on yourself. I mean you have to, it's kind of like being, I don't know, like an opera singer. You know you have to have proper breath control, embouchure support and you know it's unlike most all other wind instruments. Maybe French horn is maybe just as challenging of an instrument to perform on, but I think for me you know I put a lot of work into, Jeez, that's a tough question. But you know what? What I did in college is I did a whole bunch of transcribing. I transcribed as many different trumpet players as a could. When I got to New England Conservatory back in 1997 I probably knew five trumpet players off the top of my head. I knew Clifford Brown's playing, I had transcribed some of him; Miles Davis; I was familiar with Dizzy; Louis Armstrong; and Freddie Hubbard; and Nicholas Payton. My trumpet player in high school introduced me to the music of Nicholas Payton. We listened to "Gumbo Nouveau" and "Whoopin' Blues" was one of my first transcriptions. I transcribed him. And so when I got to NEC my teacher, bless his soul — he passed away back in September, John McNeil, told me about all these other trumpet players I needed to listen to. So what I ended up doing is, you know, going out and finding records and recordings and going to the library and listening to LPs of all the players that influenced the players that I had already listened to, you know Fats Navarro, you know Roy Eldridge, you know Chet Baker, Woody Shaw, Lee Morgan you know just so many other you know great players. And I started transcribing, learning as much as I could just taking in things, going to concerts and you know sneaking into Wally's you know I was underage at the time. So I did a lot of transcribing and just absorbing different styles in the hopes of trying to get to a point where I had like a visualization of like going into a room of like a whole bunch of trumpet players and saying okay Miles is over here, Fats is over here, bla-bla-bla, bla-bla-bla. This is the whole trumpet creative space. Where's the empty space where I can find where I can just lay, you know, all of the stuff that I'm playing and just be there and have it be a thing where it's identifiable but it's still influenced by everybody else in the room. So I tried to absorb as many different styles as possible in order to try to find who I truly am as a creative person you know so when someone listens to me they'll say, "Okay that's Jason because there's a little bit of Booker Little, there's a little bit of Freddie,

there's a little bit of who — but it's all — it's none of those people it's just like a combination of all those people. And so you know I want to say that people that hire me might hear that in my playing, but you know that's kind of not a question for me I guess. On the other side of it I really enjoy like playing in other people's bands and helping them bring their music to life. You know I end up getting called to play in bands with people who write really complicated music that's beautiful at the same time. So I don't know that could be a thing. I don't know there's a handful of us that are in that realm. You know when I listen to other trumpet players who have influenced me and my generation like that I think of people like Ambrose Akinmusire, Jonathan Finlayson, Sean Jones, Philip Dizak, Adam O'Farrill, you know those trumpet players they have that thing where they have a very unique, recognizable voice and they also have this musicality that allows them to be almost chameleon-like where they can fit into a lot of different situations, which is something that we kind of have to have nowadays because you know very few people I know play in just one band and they just do that. You know, unless you're a leader and you've got a lot of support. But you know as a trumpet player you know I've made a hefty amount of my career has been playing as a sideperson in other people's bands. You know I'm doing my first tour as a leader overseas in October of this year. And I'm 46 years old and I've never taken a band out under my own name. So all the traveling that I've done has been in other people's bands up until now.

MR: Congratulations on that.

JP: Oh, thanks.

MR: You make me think of, you're talking about finding your own sound, and when we started this interview project back thirty years ago I was speaking with the older generation and a lot of them would say, "well everybody sounds the same now." You know the sax players sound like either Charlie Parker or John Coltrane, and Sweets Edison was going on about how in his day you could recognize someone in one note, and he said this, he said, "We used to say we'd rather be the world's worst originator than the world's greatest imitator."

JP: Um hum. Yeah.

MR: And as for Sweets, he's a good example. He plays a couple of notes and you can usually tell him.

JP: Yeah. Absolutely.

MR: Your sound reminds me of, I don't know if you're familiar with Joe Wilder.

JP: Oh I love Joe Wilder. Oh I've got a story about that.

MR: Oh yeah?

JP: You know when I was a student at New England Conservatory I befriended the great trumpet player Jeremy Pelt. He pulled me off the street, he literally pulled me off the

street — I was walking down Mass Ave in Boston, had my trumpet case over my back, and I was coming back from Tower Records going down Mass Ave, past Berklee, which he was about to graduate from, and I was going towards New England Conservatory. He saw a trumpet on my back and he said, "You play trumpet?" I said, "Yeah." He said, "Are you going to Berklee?" I said, "No I go to NEC." He said, "Oh, you're going to NEC." And so he said, "I want you to come with me." And this was on a Sunday. So we walked down Mass Ave and we went past my turn to get to NEC further down Mass Ave and we went to a club called Wally's. And I had never been there, I'd never heard of the place, but they were having a jam session. And so he brought me in, he's like, "Okay I want you to play something for me. Go over there and play a tune, I want to hear you play." And so I went up and I played, I'll never forget, I played "Out of Nowhere." I barely knew the tune you know so I just kind of played by ear. And he's like, "Oh you sound good" blah-blah-blah but you need to work on this, you need to work on that, come over to my house next week and I'll give you a lesson. You know I never met this guy but he told me to come over. And so I went over to his house and he started playing some records for me. And he told me about Joe Wilder. And so he said, "Yeah there's this record I've been looking for called "Wilder and Wilder" and if you find it, you know, let me know and you should buy it man, we can listen to it together. And so that summer, so a whole school year passed and I went home for the summer, I went — I'm from North Carolina. And I went home and one particular night I was going to go to the grocery store. I forget what store it was, it was like a Target kind of store where they had food and you know miscellaneous things shopping stuff. And so I had just enough money to get some food because I was going to buy dinner and cook some dinner at home. I think I had like twenty bucks or something. So I got some groceries, I was standing in line to go check out and right next to the bubble gum section was Joe Wilder "Wilder and Wilder" I kid you not. It's like it was placed there right for me. And I only had $20 to my name. I put the food back and I got that record. It was a CD from an LP.

MR: I have it.

JP: Um hum. Yeah, that version of "Cherokee" — when students want to learn "Cherokee" I'll say you've got to learn it slow, listen to this, you know, and Joe Wilder's playing is so angular, and it's 1956 and it sounds like it could have been recorded, you know, yesterday. He and Hank Jones, oh man, their playing's just so fresh and his sound — so lyrical, his tone. He could have played in any major orchestra.

MR: Yeah. In fact, that was his aspiration when he — I got to know him fairly well and he wanted to be in a classical situation. And at the time there was no black players in — you know it was just not an opportunity that he could pursue. And you can hear that classical

training sometimes in his improvising or his articulation. So thanks for sharing that story. That really makes me smile.

JP: Me too.

MR: Yeah. The current scene that — you're saying after all these years you finally led a band. Do you have to get an agent to really make that happen for you?

JP: Yeah well you know the — I have a local band, you know a band of cats in Boston that I play with regularly. You know we did a concert last week for International Jazz Day. And so that band, you know we've done things, you know, regionally. We played the Chicago Jazz Festival and stuff. But for my latest, my last two or three records I've used people in New York and so there are slightly different projects with different kinds of compositions and everything. And so I recently got an agent, a booking agent, that's based in Berlin. The organization is called Attaché +++. And it's run by, the director used to work with the agency that booked Kurt Rosenwinkel. And her name is Charlotte Jestaedt, and she started her own company. And so she's been bringing in people and so when my latest record "The Crossover" came out back in December, we decided to try to throw some dates together to feature the players on that band, on that record, and so Mark Turner is on that record and Marcus Gilmore and Larry Grenadier. And so we're trying to sell that record, and I've got Mark on the tour, he was available to do it, and Jeff Ballard is able to do it, Marcus Gilmore wasn't able to do it. So in order to like have certain venues have interest, since me myself I haven't worked a lot as a leader. So I kind of have to have some high-powered people as side people in my project in order to get interest from a lot of venues on the European circuit. So yeah, I don't think I could have put together the dates that I have — it's going to be in October — I don't think I could have done it by myself. I think I would have needed somebody like Charlotte that's on the inside, that's already been working with, you know these various venues. But it's not impossible. I do know people who, you know, put tours together by themselves and you know, they'll work all the logistics and do all the booking and everything. So you know that kind of thing isn't impossible you know.

MR: You brought up "The Crossover," and I had a question about — I think that's the name of the tune as well, correct?

JP: Um hum, yes.

MR: And I was listening to it and I couldn't find one.

JP: Oh okay. It's in three.

MR: Okay. I was thinking it's very complex, all the parts together, and I wondered if you heard that in your head before you wrote it down or was it — sometimes when I use Finale I write things almost by accident, and I hear them back and I go, "Hey, I like that!" You know I wish I'd thought of it, but it sort of was a happy accident.

JP: Yeah I mean, yeah I write everything from up here. I don't write from an instrument. I mean I've written a few tunes from the instrument, from the trumpet or, you know I started playing guitar a little bit. But I've never really written a full tune off of the instrument. But I think, but that tune there is a four chord motif in the beginning that's similar to a Tadd Dameron turnaround. You know you've got the one and then the flat three and you know the flat six, you know that resolves back to the one. And so I put all of that in three. And so the pulse is here — I don't want to get too nerdy but it's like [scats] one-two-three — so it's one-two-three, one-two-three [scats]. And the bass part is on the E of the preceding beat. So that's why it's kind of hard to really hear where one is. But the drummer, Marcus, he lays down where one is. So the rhythmic thing in Marcus' playing can really show you where it all is.

MR: Thank you. I'll go back and listen to that now, and I can sleep tonight.

JP: Yeah, it's in three where the quarter note is about 100 beats a minute.

MR: Yeah. All right. I've got a question I've been working on and maybe you can help me actually just form it, but it seems that jazz has had differing and changing roles in society, if we think back in its very early days it was "new" music, then it became really high entertainment pop music, sort of in the swing era. In the '50s you had sort of bebop characters and the Dizzy Gillespie sort of persona. Some civil rights connections in the '60s. This is all my own opinion, but do you feel that jazz has a role in society, American society now? What is the role of jazz?

JP: Yeah I think it has the role to tell the truth about, you know, the individual's experience. The collective experience of, you know, whoever the artist is and where they are geographically, regionally, and also to be able to tell the story and have what you have to present be something that you can share with people. I think this music is a social music. It's a music that's meant to be, you know, played, for people, you know with people. And yeah I think that's something that we can really benefit from in terms of like really knowing what the possibilities of playing an instrument in a creative way can be. That's why I don't think this music will ever go away because the creative aspect of it will always draw people in to want to play. Even if there are no gigs. You know people will find a way to make their own gigs, make their own possibilities. Go play on the porch. You know there are porch-fests everywhere up in New England you know. There were some in my neighborhood when I was living in Boston you know. So there's like a very local component that I think needs to be grown and nurtured, especially when you look at all the defunding that's happened with the arts organizations and everything that's going on now. I think we're really going to have to really show the importance of playing music together. It's just as important as throwing a basketball or passing something. The importance of cooperation, teamwork, listening and building and getting better and

development, that's all in this type of music. And also there are so many things that we can learn about it because it's intergenerational. You know I could go and play with 15-year-olds. I played with a young tenor player last night named Emilio Modeste. I mean he's the spitting image of — like I thought I was playing next to Wayne Shorter and he's probably half my age. You know and then I played with Sharon Jones, the great singer that's in her seventies. And so I think that aspect of it, the social aspect and the history of it along with what we can contribute to it, you know there's always something new that we can contribute to it because there's always new stories that have a soundtrack to them. You know and we can also write based on history. You know and sometimes you know you put out projects and it informs people of the history because you just put out a project and it informs them. Like I did a project on the stolen artwork from the Isabella Stewart Gardner museum. I wrote a piece for every piece of art that was stolen. And so —

MR: I was going to ask you about that because I noticed some interesting titles in your work. "A Line for Dr. Cornel West" and even an inspiration for the Sudoku Suite. Do you — I'm not sure how to ask this — do you look for inspiration or does it arrive somehow and you take note of it.

JP: Yeah, that's a heavy question. You know I've gone through periods where I'll have several months where I'll just go and go to a museum, like I went to the Gardner Museum and I just noticed the empty frames. And I said to myself what does that mean? And then I found out what those empty frames in the museum meant, it was symbolism hoping for those stolen pieces of artwork to come back. And so then I went online and I found the actual pieces of artwork and I just stared at them and read about the history of them and the artists. And I tried to infuse the techniques that they used in those paintings into the compositions that I wrote. You know there's a Rembrandt painting called "A Lady and Gentleman in Black" and it's a painting of them and they're dressed in black and they look very regal and it looks like they're about to go have a night on the town. And so I wrote a song where the melody is comprised of all black notes on the piano. So stuff that's like literal, to that degree. And then some other things that are a little more subtle but yeah, those kind of things, when you can connect history and you know current events with music, you know I think this music is more malleable than other genres I'd say, that you can fuse, you know melodic content, you can bring in multimedia disciplines and then you've got the whole improvisational piece to it where you can really express how you feel about something, all within one song. You know that's what makes the music really unique.

MR: That's a terrific answer. Have you ever written a piece that has no improvisation at all in it?

JP: I don't think I have, no. That's my next goal I guess.

MR: Well the reason I asked is I've done a few and it's always the same thing, you feel it's going well and you listen back to it and yeah I like it. And then you look at the — in my case the clock on Finale and, oh okay I've written 90 seconds of music. It's tedious because we get so used to maybe having a set of chord changes and writing this nice melody and we're happy, and then we're going to stretch it out, we're going to improvise on it.

JP: Yup, yup. Yeah I've written some songs where I didn't have the goal of myself improvising on the song, like I wrote them for other people. I think I first heard that on a Jeremy Pelt record. He recorded a song, I forget the name of it, but he didn't even solo in the song and I thought oh this is cool, you know, it's his record and he wrote the song and there's these other people soloing on it but he didn't solo on it. That's really generous. But yeah, I think the next level is to write a song that's just through-composed and just have it really be its own thing. Yeah, I think it's a mental thing where for me I've always written where the improvisational part of the piece is the goal, the arrival point. Like you write this melody to get to the solos as opposed to you know the other way around. You know I did a trio record that's going to come out this winter in December. And playing trio with trumpet, bass and drums was really challenging to try to have the set of music not be so much where it's like head, solo, head. And so there are a few pieces where, you know I wrote out a sketch of a melody and some chord changes but I said to the band, "Okay let's just start, we're just going to start improvising and then we're going to play the melody at the very end of the song or in the middle of the song." And then have it be something like that. So yeah, so it's a journey and a path, but I think yeah, writing the song with no improvisation and just see how you can develop it, and I think that's a really great idea.

MR: Over the years I've had, especially in middle school-aged, promising musicians but they were really shy. And I saw you speak in an interview and you described yourself as a quiet person. And I used to say to these shy young musicians, "Think of your instrument like a prop, like when an actor gets a cane and a hat they're transforming themselves." And I wonder if you ever thought about your trumpet as a prop that allows me to step outside of my regular personality?

JP: Yeah I think the trumpet has that ability more so than other instruments. You know I taught in the public schools for about 12, 13 years and I taught woodwind and brass. I taught clarinet, you know, tenor, alto, trombone, I had some trumpet students. And yeah it's like the trumpet has a certain magnetism that attracts certain types of people, you know really loud outspoken people or maybe really reserved people that want to have something that's on the opposite end of what they are. And then you have some that have something that they want to be exactly what that is, you know I want to be loud and

brass, Maynard Ferguson style. And then you have other people, it's like I really want to make this brass instrument that wants to be loud and high be something that's more subtle like Chet Baker or, you know somebody else. So yeah for me it's probably a mix of that. But I say I've really gotten a little bit out of my — I mean I've gotten older and, you know, developed more as a person and so I've kind of come out of my shell that way but I think just being on the educational side of things really opened me up and I've really gotten an education. Back in 1998 I went home during one of the holiday breaks, back home to North Carolina. And I have a younger brother who, he was in grade school at the time. And I went to his school and I read a children's book, a few childrens' books to his class. He was in about third or fourth grade, I can't remember what grade he was in. But I went to the library and I read to all of them and just to see their faces really light up after I was reading something to them and saying oh wow, I can make a difference in these young childrens' lives. Let me learn more about music and maybe I could teach. You know? So just by having that experience it kind of influenced me to — it inspired me to get to a point where I could learn more so I'd be able to share more and that helped me come out of my shell. So I think just being in a classroom so much has kind of helped me not be as shy and be as quiet as I described in what you read.

MR: I think you're right. And among the things I've done, one of the toughest was learning how to deal with like kindergarten and first grade classes. You know if you can figure that out, that makes a lot of other things just seem easy.

JP: Yup. Um hum. Yup. I had a few of those classes, and every semester when I was teaching in Boston I always bring in music. You know we learn how to plan everything but I'll say okay we've got to listen to some music. So I'd sit them all down, I'd put on a recording of Monk — Thelonious Monk — and I'd tell the kids, "Okay, when this music comes on do whatever you want to do, just don't hurt anybody." And nine times out of ten they all danced to Monk. And so I was like okay, this is what the music does for people when they don't have any inhibitions. You know? They always would dance. It's like okay, that's what it is.

MR: That's a heck of a coincidence because last night on the way home they were playing Thelonious Monk on the Sirius jazz station and it was so — he was really into hitting these chords where no one else would do it and, you know, Charlie Rouse was, I mean the whole thing was very physical. And so I can almost picture that class you are talking about.

JP: Um hum. Yeah, yeah.

MR: I wanted to ask you about a particular gig and this is probably going to be tough because this was in 2019, and the video of it is online, a gig with Jerry Bergonzi, and you started out with "Stablemates." No piano. I wonder if that probably was a choice, like you lay

out on the first tune. But there was a moment after that and you were going to play, you followed that with "All the Things You Are." But there was a couple minutes where you and Jerry were like, put your heads together and you were having a conversation. And I think it was something to observe for students. Can you possibly recall what you were talking about?

JP Oh you mean we were physically talking?

MR: Yes. You were sort of facing the drummer. You weren't addressing the audience. It's almost like — I assumed it was like one of those things, "Okay here's what we're going to do, you play the first eight, I'll do —" you know like you were doing an instant arrangement.

JP: Yeah, yeah. We were playing up in Portsmouth at a place called the Press Room. We've done a few concerts, Jerry and I. Jerry was one of my teachers in college. One of the great artists of our time, one of the greatest tenor players ever. Great educator too. You know I took private lessons with him at NEC. Yeah I think at that moment we were either — for those gigs we didn't have a set list, so we were either talking about how the tune we were playing was going to go or what we were going to play next. And yeah, that's probably all that was. Yeah.

MR: And then it happened. And then it sounded like it was, just like it was supposed to be.

JP: Um hum.

MR: That's one of the great things about this music is that a little pre-planning can go a long way if people are being creative.

JP: Yeah. And I tell my students all the time, you know it's important to know as many tunes as possible because you never know where you're going to be. You can be on a session, at a jam session and somebody that you really admire could be in that audience and you want to play with them and so you come up and they say, "Hey let's play a tune." And they say, "Okay what'chu want to play?" You know? And they might call a tune that you know that you learned and it's like okay, then you make that musical connection. Or you could be in a place, like I've been at jam sessions in Russia where people don't speak English, I don't speak any Russian, but you just whisper over [scats] they say, "Okay yes, 'Stablemates.'" "Okay let's play that." And they say yeah, and so then we'd play that. So yeah, you know when they say it's like music is the universal language. You know there's a melodic language to it that really connects people. So yeah it's important to be able to communicate that way.

MR: One more comment about that gig followed with "Moment's Notice" and it was bright. And I was wondering, in a tune like that, at that tempo with chord changes flying by are you thinking of the chord changes as you're playing to guide your note choices? Or is it something else?

JP: Yeah I mean it's that. I mean you have to — to be able to speak on a tune it's very important to know the inner-workings of it I'd say. But I say ultimately you want to get to the point where you can play over the tune but you don't have to think about what those chord changes are, you just know what the phrase is. And you can like speak over how the melody that — because I'm a single note instrument so I can only play one note at a time. So it's like I have to know how what melody I'm playing relates to the actual melody of the song and how the voice leading works and you know how I want to resolve things. So there's a multitude of things. You know and also knowing — if I know the chord changes I also know which notes I can hold over a set a chord changes. I know the common tones. I know the guide tones. I know the rhythm of the song. You know you listen to people like Louis Armstrong, they could just play one note and just vibe on that one note and have it speak over a whole song. Just imagine Louis playing over "Moment's Notice" and it would be swinging. You know? When to use space. When not to play. When to let a chord pass by. You know? That song is so harmonically dense it's like you don't have to play on every chord change. If you feel like you need to do that then you can end up using what we will call run-on sentences, when you're playing music. And you don't want to have that kind of thing, especially as a wind instrument player. I was at a clinic by Joe Lovano years ago and he talked about how horn players are so used to having what they play when they improvise be determined by how much air they have in their lungs. And it's like they just keep playing, keep playing, keep playing, keep playing, keep playing the tune, almost out of breath — take another breath and keep playing, keep playing, keep playing. It's like that's not how we speak when we're having a conversation with people so we can't really phrase like that. So breathe, let the chord pass by, let your thoughts pass, let some space in. I find that when I get into that space then I make music that's more impactful. But for me I get excited sometimes and I want to play over every chord on every chorus. And you know you've just got to have the discipline not to have that kind of thing.

MR: Do you find that there's been occasions where you play less, a bit less, because you're working with such wonderful — a wonderful rhythm section?

JP: Yeah. Yup. Um hum. You know I've been playing with a tenor player, Mark Turner — I've been in his band for about ten years now, a little over ten years, going on eleven now I think. And we've done some clinics together at certain schools and everything. And he did this one exercise that I learned a lot from where he brought a horn player up and there was a rhythm section accompanying. And so they all played a tune. But he told the saxophone player he said, "Okay so when the tune starts I don't want you to play anything until you hear something from the rhythm section that is worth responding to, or something that you can contribute to based on what they play." Because a lot of times

horn players, they'll get up and they want to just play their stuff and have other people follow them. Whereas he said, "Okay I want you to listen. Maybe listen to the drummer's snare. Or maybe listen to the piano player's left hand, you know what kind of rhythm they're playing. Or maybe the bass player's playing a certain harmonic or something you know." And so I said wow, that's a really cool way to go in to a solo when you're improvising, just to say okay I'm going to be influenced by what I hear around me, and only play that.

MR: That takes a lot of discipline.

JP: So you don't go in playing a lick-based solo. You go in like truly improvising based on what you hear around you. And so that's a real unique tool to use.

MR: Is there anything on the bandstand that you've either observed or experienced that you find aggravating?

JP: You know at this point in my life just seeing people that aren't enjoying themselves on the bandstand. That's probably the most general answer I can give to that. You know or somebody that's just not giving energy. You know I think energy is something — you can feel it, you can hear it, and you know it when it's not there. I always hearken back to this story that I think Max Roach told about Clifford Brown where after a concert a lady came up to him, came up to Clifford and said, "You know I don't know what you played tonight but you sure played the hell out of it." You know? And so I've always tried to live on the bandstand with that kind of thing. Because you never know, Clifford died when he was 25 you know, and so everything we have of him, you could sense that he was really playing in a way where it was just reckless abandon. He was going to play his best at all times. He never really dialed it in. I can't detect any dialing in in his playing. And so when I hear players that I know and admire and, you know, come to expect something like that from, you know I mean it's disappointing. I wouldn't say aggravating, but yeah, probably disappointing. That plus as I said before, not enjoying being on stage. I think even as an audience member, you know you don't want to look like your not having a good time. You know the music's already dense enough, and to see somebody up there you know not really into it you know that's a drag. Especially if it's a gig where you like paid to go see a band and you know everybody's like this. You know play the solo and then go to the side like this. Like snap your finger a little bit. You know, get into it. Cheer your band on. Sometimes they need an uplift and they need a little yeah, something to get them inspired. You know? And you know I've had people come up to me and they'll say, "You really looked like you were enjoying yourself up there, I really enjoyed that." You know? They might not have understood the sharp nines I played on every chord or whatnot, but they say, "Yeah I really enjoyed that, you all looked like you

were having fun up there. You sound like you were a band." And we need more of that. Every band needs to do that.

MR: You just reminded me of the last time I did adjudicating at a high school festival and we were required to go up and talk to the band afterwards. And I went up and I said, "You know the band sounds great, it's okay for you to smile." All the students were so like serious and there was no acknowledgement of their fellow band members when they got up to solo or anything. I said, "You've got to like loosen up." And as you said, it's contagious.

JP: Yup. Yup.

MR: The audience is going to like your band better if you do that. They may not even know why.

JP: Yeah. That's another thing is, yeah I don't want to go too deep into it but just being able to relate to the audience outside of just playing. You know when you play a tune, explain what the tune is. Explain the name of it, if it has a story it's just going to inform them and maybe they'll imagine it differently when they hear it. So you know I think it would benefit us greatly to have the ability to be able to speak about the music that we make, that we compose. You know we've got to able to give a 30-second elevator speech as to why we should have our band hired. You know? Or what makes it great? You know. So you know when I go hear a band and they just play the whole time and not say anything to the audience, I mean that's happened before. And I get it, I mean some people are quiet. You know I even play, I play in certain bands with certain leaders who are very quiet and you know, even me, I'll just say the leader's name at the end of the concert. Ba-ba-ba. Check him out, yeah and everybody claps. But yeah just a few words about what you do I think goes a long way and it helps sell the music. You know? You say, "I wrote a song about my three cats and we're going to play it right now and it's on my new record." And the at the end of the concert somebody comes up to you and says, "We really liked that cat song, and we've got some cats at home, can I buy your record?"

MR: It reminds me of the three times I saw Cannonball Adderley years ago. He was a master of that.

JP: Yup. Great orator. Yup.

MR: Yeah. This has been a marvelous conversation. I'll wrap up with one more quote, and I think you'll be familiar with this, because it comes from your website. "Supporting live music is environmentally friendly, stimulates local economies, and feeds the soul. Skip the things, invest in experiences."

JP: Yeah, uh hum, yup. Absolutely. Yeah I think I touched on that earlier when we were talking about the local thing being the thing just growing communities and it's kind of like a web, like a spider web. If you look, like back in the days we had circuit bands. You

know you'd travel the circuit. Because you'd go to a community and they had their thing. You know territory bands and all that good stuff. You know. It's all important. It's more important now I'd say. We need art very much now. So yeah, absolutely.

MR: Yeah, get off the computer and go see something live.

JP: Yeah absolutely. Um hum. Um hum.

MR: Well thank you, Jason. This has been a delight. And I hope your European tour is a big hit.

JP: Thank you so much. Yeah I appreciate that, Monk. Yeah absolutely. We're going to have some fun.

MR: All right. I'll just pause us here and we'll say our good-byes.

JP: Yup.